THREE

Reconciliation

BY LUNCHTIME THE next day, eleven people had read it.

I know this because the blogging platform tells you, in a small grey number at the top of the screen, the way a hospital monitor tells you your pulse. Eleven. I refreshed it while my toast burned. Thirteen. One of them, I was fairly sure, was me on my phone.

By the end of the week it was four hundred. I don't know how. Someone shared it somewhere, and someone else shared that, and the small grey number started to climb the way water climbs a cloth. There were comments. Most were kind. Some were funny. A man in a city I'd never been to explained, at length and with great confidence, that the stamp was obviously a brand of Victorian fertiliser. A woman wrote just *I believe you*, and I didn't know what to do with that, because I hadn't claimed anything. One stranger offered, politely, to have me sectioned.

And on the Friday, a reader with a cartoon owl for a picture wrote one line:

Could D. 3062 be a count of days? Like a ship's log?

I read it standing at the kitchen counter, and I said *oh* out loud, to no one, in the voice you use when you've been looking for your

glasses and they're on your head. I'd spent eleven years with dates. I'd looked at that number for four days. A stranger with an owl had seen it in a morning.

I was annoyed. I want that on the record. It's the most honest thing in this chapter.

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I HAD NINE days of notice left, and a keycard that still worked.

The archive unit was exactly as I'd left it: the boxes, the crate I used as a chair, the fluorescent strip that took a moment to make up its mind. The keycard beeped when I went in. I said *hello* to it, which tells you something about how the year had gone.

If D. 3062 was a day, it was a day in 1971, and somewhere in the unit there'd be a record of it that nobody had bothered to fake. Manifests could be doctored. Vehicle logs were a different animal. Every lorry, every day: driver, mileage out, mileage in, a one-line job reference, written by men who were tired and wanted to go home. It's the sort of paperwork that only lies about small things.

The 1971 logs were three shelves below the box I'd found the manifest in. I took them down, all twelve months of them, in ledgers with marbled covers gone soft as felt. I brought a flask. I did the first quarter line by line, over two evenings, until the letters swam and my back informed me in no uncertain terms that I was thirty-eight.

On **Wednesday the third of March, 1971**, a driver had logged a round trip with no job reference.

Where the reference belonged, in a careful hand, he'd written:

H.H. — per instr.

The mileage out and back put the destination about two and a half hours away. Somewhere rural. Somewhere you'd need instructions to find.

I sat back on my crate. Harrowgate House. Per instruction. A trip that was written down so that it would exist, and written down so that nobody could say what it was.

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SO: IF THE third of March 1971 was day 3,062, then day one was 3,062 days before it.

I did the sum by hand first, in pencil on the back of an invoice, the way Pete taught me: years, then leap years, then the months, then the remainder, checking each line before I trusted the next. Then I did it again in a spreadsheet on my phone. Then, because I no longer trusted anything I could only check twice, I did it by hand again.

Day 0 was the fourteenth of October, 1962.

I knew that date. Everyone of a certain age knows that autumn, and everyone younger has seen the documentaries: the week the whole world sat very still in front of its radios and waited to find out whether there would be a next week. I'm not going to write about it. I didn't then, either. I just sat in a storage unit by a railway line with a pencil in my hand, and felt something very old and very cold go down the back of my neck.

Somebody had started counting the day the world held its breath. And somebody had still been counting, carefully, eight and a half years later.

* * *

IF SOMETHING HAD started in October 1962, and Coyle's had been there in 1971, I wondered whether Coyle's had been there at the start.

The box marked **1962 Q4** was in the damp corner, under a drip from the roof that had been reported, according to a faded note taped to the wall, in 1997. Most of what was inside had fused into a single brick of paper, like geology: layers of invoices pressed together into one brown stone. I didn't think I'd get anything out of it. I eased a palette knife down the side the way my mother used to free a cake from a tin, and one manifest came away whole.

**Saturday, 13 October 1962. A delivery* to* Harrowgate House.

Sender: *Harlow-Vane Inst., per C.S.S. dept.*

Cargo: *OFFICE EQUIPMENT — TELETYPE APPARATUS, 1 UNIT, WITH LINE CONNECTION.*

This one was properly ordinary: a rate, an invoice number, a signature. The weight had been written in the bottom corner, but the bottom corner had gone soft and brown, and the numbers were a smudge. There was no stamp.

And underneath, in pencil, in the driver's hand, a note he hadn't needed to write:

Delivered & installed. Gent at door said would be "needed from tomorrow." Odd sort of party — 7 cars on the drive, no staff.

I read it once and then I read it again and then I put it down on my knee and looked at the wall for a while.

You have to understand what it's like, when you've spent your life with documents. Most of them are dead. They tell you a lorry went somewhere and something was carried and someone was paid. But every so often you find a line like that, a line nobody required, and the dead paper opens like a door, and there's a person standing behind it. A young man in a cab, in 1962, writing down a thing that bothered him because writing it down was the only way he knew to put it somewhere.

Needed from tomorrow. Seven cars and nobody to park them. A machine carried into that house on a Saturday, the day before somebody started counting.

I didn't know, then, what I know now. But I knew this: something had happened in that house on the fourteenth of October, 1962, and the men who moved things for a living had noticed, and written it down, and been told, in one way or another, to stop.

* * *

I WALKED HOME the long way, past the old head office, because my feet decided to.

It's flats now, the old building near the goods yard: the lettering chiselled off the stone, the windows replaced with the kind that

don’t open. My father worked on the second floor for thirty years. If you’d asked anyone at Coyle’s where a document was, in any year between 1979 and 2009, they’d have said *ask Emmanuel*, and he’d have taken off his reading glasses and told you the shelf, the box, and probably the colour of the folder.

He’d have known about the 1962 box. He’d have known about the drip, and the note from 1997. He’d have known which drivers did the runs that never went on the board.

I stood across the road from the building with my bag on my shoulder and the scan inside it, and I took out my phone to ring him.

I got as far as his name in my contacts before I remembered. Seven years, and it still happens: a half-second where he’s alive, and then the floor goes. I’ve never deleted the number. I don’t know who has it now. Some days I think about ringing it to find out, and some days I’m afraid someone will answer.

I put the phone away. A man came out of the flats with a dog, and looked at me standing there staring at his front door, and I walked on before he could ask.

It didn’t occur to me, that evening, to wonder why my father had never once mentioned a house called Harrowgate. It would. But not yet.

* * *

THAT NIGHT I wrote the second post.

I showed my working: the logs, the sum, the soft brown box. I thanked the owl, through gritted teeth. I left out what I’d felt in the archive, because I couldn’t make it sound like anything other than a woman alone in a shed being frightened by a date. I wrote that I’d come back to the Harlow-Vane Institute, whatever it had been. I posted it at a quarter to midnight and went to bed, and for once I slept.

If I’d looked at the page that night, really looked at it, at the parts of a web page people don’t usually see, I might have noticed

that at twelve minutes past three in the morning, while I was asleep, someone else had been there too. I didn't look. Most people don't.

* * *

THERE WERE TWO retired drivers I still had numbers for. I rang them both.

The first one laughed. *Long weather? Sounds like my ex-wife.* He'd never heard of it, and he said so, and I believed him, and we talked about his allotment for twenty minutes instead.

The second one went quiet.

I'll call him Len, which is nothing like his name. He'd driven for Coyle's for forty-six years and retired the year I joined. When I said the words *for the long weather* on the phone, there was a silence long enough that I thought the line had gone. Then he said he'd meet me for a coffee, but not at his house. "The caff by the old depot," he said. "Thursday. Ten." And he rang off before I could thank him.

The café by the old depot is the kind of place that's been about to close since 1985. Formica tables, a laminated menu with photographs of the food that the food has never lived up to, a radio playing to itself. Len was already there when I arrived, in the corner seat with his back to the wall, and I understood without being told that he'd chosen it.

He was a big man gone thin, the way big men do: the frame still there, the weight gone somewhere else. He had a mug of tea in both hands. When I put the scan on the table between us, he didn't pick it up for a long time. Then he held it at arm's length, the way people hold photographs of the dead.

This is as close to his words as I can get. I wrote them down in the car afterwards, with my hands not quite steady.

"Twice a year, maybe. Never on the board. The office'd ring you at home the night before. You'd not get the job sheet in the cab. You'd collect, you'd deliver, and a fella'd meet you at the far

end and pay you, separate. Cash. Polite. Good suit. You'd not remember his face after. Not a bad face. Just one that didn't stick."

He turned the scan face down on the table, gently, as if it might wake.

"The stamp was on the office copy, not yours. You'd only see it if you went looking. I went looking the once."

I asked what he'd carried.

"Machines, mostly." Teletypes, early on. Later, "them fax things". And once, in the eighties, something the size of a wardrobe, in a crate, that took four men to lift. He drove it out to the country house the old drivers called H.H. "And it hummed," he said. "With the power off. You could feel it in the cab, through the seat. Like a fridge, but there was no plug on it." He heard himself say it, and looked at his tea as though the tea had been talking. "I'm probably remembering it wrong."

I asked about the man who'd written the 1962 note. I showed him the handwriting.

He knew it. Of course he did. "Old Tommy," he said. "Before my time, that run. First one, they reckoned. Never talked about it. Not for years. Then when he got old he never talked about anything else. Used to go on about seven cars and a man with no face. We thought he'd gone soft." He was quiet for a moment. "Died, what, ten years since. I didn't go to the funeral. Should have."

And then I asked him why he'd gone quiet on the phone.

He put his mug down. He lined it up with the edge of the table, carefully, like a man squaring a stack of paper.

"Because my mate Terry asked," he said. "Back in the eighties. Asked the office who the cash man was. Just asked. Friendly, like. And then Terry wasn't on long-distance any more. Nothing nasty. Nobody shouted. He just never got the good runs again. Local stuff till he retired. Never knew why, and never asked anything else, ever." He turned his mug a quarter-turn. "Lucky, really, Terry. Lost the good runs and kept his sleep." Len looked at me then, properly, for the first time. "You notice that sort of thing. You

notice it for forty years."

He stood up. He put on his coat, which took a while, and left a two-pound coin on the table for his tea even though I'd said I'd pay. At the door he turned round, and I thought he was going to say goodbye.

"You'll notice it too, now," he said. "That's what I'm telling you, love. Once you've seen it, that's you. That's the rest of your life."

The door went. The radio played to itself. I sat in the café by the old depot with a cold coffee and a scan of a piece of paper from 1971, and I understood that he hadn't been warning me off.

He'd been welcoming me.